

Between the Lines — mark schemes, Papers A to D

TUTOR COPY • FOUR PAPERS • 25 MARKS EACH

One booklet for all four papers. The note under each question is the point of this document: it names the specific mistake the question was built to catch, and says how to mark it. The pattern to watch across the four papers is the explanation mark — a correct quotation followed by an explanation that only restates it is the single largest source of dropped marks in this topic.

Paper A — The Round

MEDIUM • 25 MARKS

- 1(a)** Any two of: she counts the eleven tins at the gate and counts them again at the corner [2]
[1]

she has taken the list out of her pocket four times already, so the folds are going soft

[1]

she carries the list at all, when her father does not.

Both marks need separate evidence. “She is nervous” and “she is worried” is one idea twice — award one. The soft folds are the answer most students walk past, because the detail is about paper rather than about Meera.

- 1(b)** He has done the round so long that it is all memorised. [1]

The careless option is chosen by students reading “does not carry” as a failing rather than as evidence of nineteen years. Point them at the list of names that follows it.

- 2(a)** arms are shaking [1]

If they give a whole clause, no mark: the question specified three words, and precision is the thing being tested. Counting the words before writing is the habit worth building here.

- 2(b)** landing [1]

Accept nothing else. “Floor” and “stairs” are both in the passage and both wrong — the definition given is specific.

- 3** Any two of: she turns the dented tin so the dent faces in [1] [2]

she puts the crate exactly where he leaves it, wheel against the wall [1]

she washes the tins; she returns the list to the drawer with the folds flattened out.

The folds being flattened is the strongest answer, because she is erasing the evidence of her own anxiety, not just tidying. Credit it warmly if it appears.

- 4** Either opinion may be chosen; the marks are for the quotations and explanations, not the box. [4]

For the second opinion: “A woman opens the door before she knocks” [1] — she was already waiting, so she knew Meera would be coming and how long the stairs take [1]
“not talking, not going back inside” [1] — she stays without making conversation, so Meera can rest without it being called resting [1]

Cap at 2 if both quotations prove the same point. The commonest loss here is quoting “Tell him Mrs Kamath asked after him” twice in two forms.

- 5** Any two, each with a feature named: “Appa does it in 50” — family word plus numerals, [4]
written as she would say it [2]

“which was weird, and then also nice? Both.” — a question asked of nobody and answered in a fragment, so the reader watches her think [2]

also accept “(402)”, “Did the round. Did NOT die.”, or the joke about the notebook.

One mark for the quotation, one for an explanation that names a feature. “This is informal” is the question repeated back and earns nothing.

- 6(a)** piece [1]

- 6(b)** She has realised how much her father knows that is never said aloud, and that the list she needed is the measure of the distance between them — respect, with some feeling of being small alongside it. [1]
Accept any answer that gets the contrast between his memory and her paper. Do not accept “she thinks he is clever” on its own.
- 7** **He packs for the worst thing that could happen, every time.** [1]
The “expects his daughter to be careless” option catches students who read the clause as being about Meera. It is about how he packs, every day, for everyone.
- 8** Any two features, named: capitals for spoken emphasis; sentences with no verb; a note she must keep from her father; the family word “Appa”; the flat number in brackets; she talks about the notebook itself. [2]
Features means the furniture of the text type. “It is about her day” is a summary and scores zero, however accurate.
- 9(a)** Meera: “puts the empty crate exactly where he leaves it, wheel against the wall” or “Doing it again tomorrow” [1] [2]
 Her father: “he does not carry the list” or “packed the way he packs everything” [1]
One phrase for each character. Two phrases about Meera caps at one mark even if both are excellent — the question named both.
- 9(b)** Tins at the gate **1**; list out for the fourth time **2**; Mrs Kamath’s water **3**; the dented lid **4**; the notebook **5**. [3]
 All four correct [3]; three correct [2]; two correct [1].
The dent and the water are the pair most often swapped, because the water is the more memorable scene. Order comes from the lines, not from how much the reader noticed.

Paper B — The Dog on the Maidan

MEDIUM • 25 MARKS

- 1(a)** Any two of: it arrives at the same time every day [1] [2]
 it sits behind the stumps “as though somebody has paid it to be there” [1]
 it watches the ball rather than the boys; it never chases.
“It never once chases” is the strongest, because chasing is what strays do. Students who answer “it is brown with one ear up” have given description, not behaviour — no mark.
- 1(b)** **Vikram has been timing it, so he has been watching for some time.** [1]
The question is really about who noticed, not about the dog. Nobody knows a four-minute gap unless they have been checking.
- 2(a)** “which Vikram does not say” (accept “does not say”). [1]
- 2(b)** **cut** [1]
- 3** Any two of: he takes two wickets and does not enjoy either [1] [2]
 he walks the long way round the maidan, past the roller and the gap in the fence [1]
 he looks at the ground rather than at anything in particular.
The two wickets are the key evidence and the one most often missed: taking wickets is the thing he came for, and it has stopped counting.
- 4** Either opinion. For the second: “the only thing he can think of” [1] — admits he has no plan, which supports the first opinion, so a good answer handles it [1]
 “he has not once thought about the two wickets” [1] — the thing he came for has stopped mattering, which is a change of loyalty rather than a lack of ideas [1]
Full marks require the two quotations to make different points. Reward any student who quotes evidence for the opinion they did not choose and then explains it away.

- 5** Any two, each explained: “Now listen.” — two words, imperative, ends the polite opening and marks where the letter turns **[2]** [4]
 “I am not going to say what you want me to say” — names his motive for writing before answering it, so he cannot pretend he was only asking **[2]**
 “Half is worse than neither” — five words, no softening, and phrased as a rule rather than an opinion **[2]**
Do not accept the example given in the paper. The mark for explanation is for naming what the language does; “she is being blunt” repeats the question.
- 6(a) free** [1]
- 6(b)** She thinks half-kindness is worse than none: the dog will now wait for him on days he cannot come, and will not understand why it has been abandoned. [1]
Students who answer “she thinks he should stop feeding it” have missed the last line of the letter. She is asking him to commit, not to withdraw — and line 43 proves it.
- 7 A partly-kept promise leaves the dog worse off than none at all.** [1]
The chapati option is bait for anyone answering from memory of line 13 rather than reading line 39 in context.
- 8** Any two: the opening address “My dear Vikku”; the signature “— Ammamma”; second person throughout; it answers questions the reader cannot see; a shared family memory from 1971. **[2]**
Answering questions we never saw is the sophisticated answer. Credit it fully — it shows the student has noticed that a letter is one half of something.
- 9(a)** Text A: “the dog knows the sound of the zip” or “the exact place... the exact moment” **[1]** [2]
 Text B: “is not a free animal any more” or “Bring the dog if by then it is yours” **[1]**
The pairing is the point: he shows it through a routine he will not name, she says it outright. Either may be quoted, but one from each text.
- 9(b)** Chapati **1**; dog absent **2**; found behind the tank **3**; sits until seven **4**; letter arrives **5**. [3]
 All four correct **[3]**; three **[2]**; two **[1]**.
The chapati is given as the example precisely because it is told in flashback at line 13 — students who order by where events appear on the page rather than when they happened get this one wrong every time.

Paper C — Block Four

HARD · 25 MARKS

- 1(a)** Any two of: she has not looked at the water **[1]** [2]
 she has stood on the same two tiles for six minutes **[1]**
 she looks at the clock, the roof, the parents and her own feet — anywhere but the race.
Not looking at the water is the best answer available and it is a negative — a thing that does not happen. Students trained only to hunt for actions miss it.
- 1(b) She presented it as settled, so that it could not be argued with.** [1]
“Genuinely delighted” is not a stupid answer; it is simply not what the sentence is built to show. Ask what “while doing something else” is doing there.
- 2(a) ordinary fourth place** [1]
- 2(b) settle** [1]

- 3** Any two of: “has not told anyone, including herself” **[1]** [2]
 “in any sentence that used actual words” — she has known it without ever phrasing it **[1]**
 the correction “Not the racing.” — she narrows it the moment she has said it.
This question is really about how a thought can be held without language, and the phrase “actual words” is the evidence. Accept nothing vague about “deep down”.
- 4** Either opinion. For the second: “Her arms decide” **[1]** — the decision is given to her body, so she never chose to win and cannot take credit or blame **[1]** [4]
 “the only place nobody can see it” **[1]** — she hides her face at the moment she is expected to celebrate, which suggests what she feels is not what a winner should **[1]**
The strongest answers notice that her mother is already turning away to talk to someone else, so the face is hidden from an audience that has stopped looking. Reward that.
- 5** Any two, each explained: “are not villains” **[1]** — he names and rejects the harshest reading before anyone can accuse him of it **[1]** [4]
 “They are usually right about the talent” **[1]** — he concedes the parents’ strongest point, which makes his disagreement about method rather than motive **[1]**
 also accept “I want to be careful here”.
This is a concession-and-rebuttal question in disguise. A student who writes “he is being nice about them” has the point and not the vocabulary — award one, and give them the word.
- 6(a) passenger** [1]
- 6(b)** He does not blame the child: he treats swimming slowly as the only power she has left, while still being clear that it is a bad way to use it. [1]
Both halves are needed. “He thinks it is wrong” alone misses the sympathy, and “he understands her” alone misses the judgement.
- 7 A deliberately slow swim cannot be told apart from a genuine one.** [1]
- 8** Any two: direct advice (“My advice is always the same”); evidence by number (“perhaps two hundred children”); concession then rebuttal; direct address to “you”; the balanced if/then ending. **[2]** [2]
Naming the structure — he admits the other side first, then answers it — is worth full credit even if the student has no technical word for it.
- 9(a)** Considering it: “There is a version of this morning in which she swims badly” or “an ordinary fourth place” **[1]** [2]
 Why she did not: “Her arms decide” or “she likes the first four strokes” **[1]**
The best answers connect the two texts explicitly: Text B predicts the plan, and Text A shows the one thing the coach did not account for, which is that she enjoys part of it.
- 9(b)** Form filled **1**; told **2**; plans the fourth place **3**; starter **4**; looks at her mother **5**. [3]
 All four correct **[3]**; three **[2]**; two **[1]**.
Filling the form and being told are both in February and are given in that order in lines 7–8 — “filled in the form... found out... too”.

Paper D — The House in Mylapore

HARD • 25 MARKS

- 1(a)** Any two of: a bus ticket left at page ninety **[1]** [2]
 a photograph of someone he does not recognise, outside this house when the gate was different **[1]**
 four rupees in an envelope marked FOR THE BOY in handwriting he knows.
The answer “there are four hundred books” is about quantity and comes at line 19 — no mark inside this range. The question is about what the books contain.

- 1(b) He would rather not find out that it was not meant for him.** [1]
The strongest single inference in the paper, and it rests on one clause. Students who tick the money option have read his character from the situation rather than from the sentence.
- 2(a) Nearly** [1]
One word, as asked. It is doing an enormous amount of work: nine books out of four hundred.
- 2(b) issued** [1]
- 3** Any two of: he says nothing when his uncle proposes forcing the almirah [1] [2]
 “he would like there to be a next Saturday” [1]
 “the almirah is the reason there has to be one” — he needs a reason to return, and the locked door supplies it.
Saying nothing is an action here. Point out to any student who missed it that silence is the fourth tell — a gap — and that this paragraph is built entirely out of one.
- 4** Either opinion, though the second is far better supported. [4]
 “in handwriting he knows” [1] — the envelope is identified by the hand that wrote it rather than by what is in it [1]
 “He does not take the four rupees out of it” [1] — leaving the money inside proves the money is not the point; the object matters intact [1]
 The final sentence is two sentences on purpose. Credit any student who notices the full stop.
An answer choosing the money opinion can still score four if the quotations are handled honestly — but it almost never happens, because the evidence runs the other way. Mark what is written, not what was ticked.
- 5** Any two, each explained: “a rear room currently used for storage” [1] — the room [4]
 where Ravi found his grandfather’s life is reduced to its current function [1]
 “an original almirah and fittings” [1] — the locked almirah nobody could open becomes a selling feature, listed beside the taps [1]
 also accept “held by the same family since construction” — sixty years of one family offered as provenance.
The whole question turns on the student having connected two texts that never mention each other. If they quote well from Text B but do not link it to Text A, cap at two.
- 6(a) dated** [1]
- 6(b)** It will probably be demolished: builders buy for the plot, so the value is in the land and [1]
 the zoning rather than in the house.
Accept “knocked down”, “rebuilt”, “flats”. Do not accept “it will be repaired” — that is what “modernisation” sounds like and is not what “scope for redevelopment” means.
- 7 Nobody is living there, so a buyer can take it over at once.** [1]
- 8** Any two: euphemism (“dated”, “would benefit from comprehensive modernisation”); [2]
 age presented as provenance; formal noun phrases (“vacant possession”, “clear title”);
 no person mentioned anywhere. [2]
That no human being appears in seventeen lines about a family home is the observation worth having. Give it both marks on its own if it is explained.
- 9(a)** The almirah: in Text A it is locked, unopened, and the reason Ravi needs there to be [2]
 another Saturday [1]; in Text B it is “an original almirah and fittings”, a feature in a list [1]
 The back room is equally acceptable: the shelf of books with things inside them,
 against “a rear room currently used for storage”.
One mark for each text. An answer that only describes Text A, however moving, takes one.

9(b) Answer 1 — the quotation is three lines long and no word is picked out, and the explanation only repeats what the question already said. **[1]** [3]

Answer 2 — there is no quotation at all, and “sad” names a feeling without showing how any words produce it. **[1]**

A correct rewrite of either, following quote → zoom → so what. For example: “‘rare opportunity’ — the word *opportunity* turns one family’s loss into somebody else’s luck.”

Or: “‘He does not take the four rupees out of it’ — leaving the money inside shows he wants the envelope for the handwriting, not for what it holds.” **[1]**

The point of this question is that both faults are his own. Ask him which of the two he wrote last week. Marking somebody else’s error is identical work to marking your own and far easier to face, which is why every Paper D on this site ends here.